Ranganathittu - September Bird Guide

Low-ink A4 field guide. Four birds per page. Identification, food, habits and where to look.
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Painted Stork

Large wader

Mycteria leucocephala



Photo: Sankara Subramanian | CC BY 2.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: White stork with boldly black-and-white patterned wings, pink tertials, long yellow-orange downcurved bill and bare orange face.

Food: Fish, frogs and other small aquatic animals.

Habits: Walks through shallow water with bill partly open, sweeping it side to side and snapping shut on prey.

Look for: Shallows, exposed banks and nesting trees; often in loose groups.

Asian Openbill

Large wader

Anastomus oscitans



Photo: Vengolis | CC BY-SA 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: Grey-white stork with black flight feathers and a distinctive gap between the closed mandibles of the bill.

Food: Mainly freshwater snails; also frogs and other aquatic prey.

Habits: Probes shallows and wet fields; the specialised bill helps handle snails.

Look for: Marshy edges, wet fields, shallow channels and communal roosts.

Spot-billed Pelican

Very large waterbird

Pelecanus philippensis



Photo: This Photo was taken by Timothy A. Gonsalves. Feel free to use my photos, but …

ID: Huge greyish pelican with a long pouch bill marked with dark spots; curly hind-crown feathers are often visible.

Food: Mostly fish.

Habits: Fishes from the surface, dipping the bill and pouch; often feeds and roosts socially.

Look for: Open river channels, broad pools and nesting trees on islands.

Black-headed Ibis

Large wader

Threskiornis melanocephalus



Photo: Hari Krishnan | CC BY-SA 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: White body, naked black head and neck, black legs and a long black downcurved bill.

Food: Insects, crustaceans, molluscs, frogs and small fish.

Habits: Walks steadily while probing soft mud and shallow water with the curved bill.

Look for: Mudflats, shallow margins, wet grass and quiet backwaters.

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Eurasian Spoonbill

Large wader

Platalea leucorodia



Photo: Macmohan | CC BY-SA 3.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: Tall white bird with black legs and a long flat black bill ending in a broad spoon-shaped tip.

Food: Small fish, aquatic insects, crustaceans and tadpoles.

Habits: Sweeps the partly submerged bill rhythmically from side to side while walking.

Look for: Open shallows and calm margins where it has room to sweep-feed.

Oriental Darter

Large diving bird

Anhinga melanogaster



Photo: Charles J. Sharp | CC BY-SA 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: Long snake-like neck, dagger bill and long tail; dark body with silvery streaks on the wings and back.

Food: Fish and other aquatic prey.

Habits: Swims low with only the neck showing, spears fish underwater, then often spreads wings to dry.

Look for: Quiet channels, low branches over water and exposed drying perches.

Indian Cormorant

Medium-large diving bird

Phalacrocorax fuscicollis

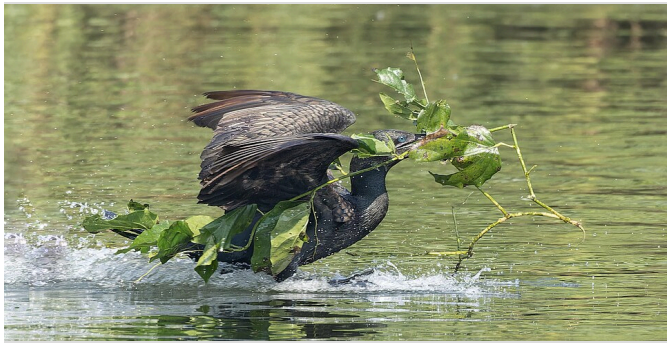


Photo: Tisha Mukherjee | CC BY-SA 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: Slim dark cormorant with a relatively long narrow bill, small peaked forehead and bright blue-green eye in good light.

Food: Fish, caught by underwater pursuit.

Habits: Dives repeatedly and may fish cooperatively; frequently sits with wings spread after feeding.

Look for: Open water, channels, snags and communal resting trees.

Grey Heron

Very large heron

Ardea cinerea



Photo: Manoj Karingamadathil | CC BY-SA 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: Tall grey-and-white heron with long yellowish bill, black head stripe and an S-shaped neck when at rest or flying.

Food: Fish, frogs, crabs, insects and small vertebrates.

Habits: Often stands motionless before striking rapidly with the bill; also stalks slowly.

Look for: Quiet banks, shallow pools, rocks and exposed river margins.

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Purple Heron

Very large heron

Ardea purpurea



Photo: Koshy Koshy from Faridabad, Haryana, India | CC BY 2.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: Slender, darker heron with chestnut-purple body tones, striped neck and a narrow snake-like profile.

Food: Fish, frogs, insects, reptiles and other small wetland prey.

Habits: Secretive; stalks through reeds and dense waterside vegetation rather than standing fully exposed.

Look for: Reedy, vegetated margins and shaded backwaters.

River Tern

Medium tern

Sterna aurantia



Photo: shrikant rao from bangalore, india | CC BY 2.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: Pale grey-and-white tern with long pointed wings, deeply forked tail and yellow bill; breeding adults show a black cap.

Food: Small fish, crustaceans and aquatic insects.

Habits: Flies buoyantly over water, then plunge-dives or dips to seize prey near the surface.

Look for: Open water, sandbars, rocks and stretches with active feeding flights.

Great Thick-knee

Large shorebird

Esacus recurvirostris



Photo: Charles J. Sharp | CC BY-SA 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: Heavy brown-grey shorebird with huge yellow eye, bold black-and-white face pattern and a thick black-and-yellow bill.

Food: Crabs, insects, molluscs and other shoreline invertebrates.

Habits: Often rests quietly by day and becomes more active toward dusk; walks deliberately on banks.

Look for: Rocky or sandy river edges, exposed islands and undisturbed banks.

Pied Kingfisher

Medium kingfisher

Ceryle rudis



Photo: Charles J. Sharp | CC BY-SA 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: Striking black-and-white kingfisher with shaggy crest; frequently hovers over water before diving.

Food: Mostly small fish; also aquatic invertebrates.

Habits: Hovers in one spot, folds its wings and plunges headfirst; often returns to an exposed perch.

Look for: Open river channels, poles, branches and wires close to water.